

Reason is the slave of passions



Letting our hearts rule our heads sometimes has tragic consequences, such as the deaths of Shakespeare's Romeo and Juliet.

Hume effectively removed all grounds for relying on reason in dealing with the world around us. For our expectations of the future, he suggested that we let custom be our guide, advocating a 'mitigated scepticism' that appeals to common sense. Still, he recognized that we generally make judgements and take decisions based on our emotional and instinctive drives, what he called 'the passions', rather than our reason.

More often than not, he observed, our reason is overruled by our passions, and we only use rational thought to justify or satisfy them. Emotions such

as love and hate, and drives such as hunger, libido and self-preservation, are very powerful and persuasive, even in situations where reason tells us there are no rational grounds for our decision. Because, in Hume's phrase, reason is the slave of the passions, we sometimes make the wrong judgements – but on balance it is better to do something to satisfy our passions than to deny our essential urges because we have no rational justification for them.